

Ancient-Medieval History

Later Medieval(1526-1757AD)

Exam: UPSC CSE (Prelims)

1. Vijayanagara Empire

Tier: tier2 • Weightage: 7.407 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 14 • Year span: 2003–2024 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:28

TopicDemandMap: Vijayanagara Empire (1526–1757 AD)

Explicit Subtopics Tested (with Evidence)

1. Dynastic Succession and Ruling Houses

- Focus: Identification and sequence of Vijayanagara dynasties (Sangama, Saluva, Tuluva, Aravidu), key transitions, and notable rulers.
- Evidence: 1612, 1750, 5152, 5147

2. Foreign Visitors and Their Accounts

- Focus: Recognition of foreign travelers (e.g., Nicolo de Conti, Abdur Razzaq, Afanasy Nikitin, Fernao Nuniz), their observations, and their significance for reconstructing history.
- Evidence: 5161, 836

3. Administrative Structure and Military Organization

- Focus: Features of governance (Amaranayakas, titles, royal orders, religious legitimacy), military administration, and tribute systems.
- Evidence: 5159, 5142

4. Economic Policies and Taxation

- Focus: Taxation under Krishnadeva Raya, land revenue, industry taxes.
- Evidence: 336

5. Architecture, Rituals, and Urban Features

- Focus: Identification of ritual platforms (e.g., Mahanavami Dibba), city planning, and monumental constructions (e.g., dams, aqueducts).

- Evidence: 5156, 1009

6. Relations with Contemporary States and Foreign Powers

- Focus: Diplomatic interactions, such as granting permission to the Portuguese for fort construction.
- Evidence: 1137

7. Rediscovery and Historiography

- Focus: Modern rediscovery of Vijayanagara sites (e.g., Hampi by Colin Mackenzie).
- Evidence: 5164

8. Role of Women and Social Life (as per Foreign Accounts)

- Focus: Skills and activities of women in society (wrestling, astrology, accounting, soothsaying).
- Evidence: 836

9. Contextual Chronology

- Focus: Correlation of Vijayanagara rulers with events in neighboring regions (e.g., founding of Mysore).
- Evidence: 2010

Logical Study Sequence

- 1 Dynastic Succession and Ruling Houses
- 2 Contextual Chronology
- 3 Administrative Structure and Military Organization
- 4 Economic Policies and Taxation
- 5 Architecture, Rituals, and Urban Features
- 6 Foreign Visitors and Their Accounts
- 7 Role of Women and Social Life (as per Foreign Accounts)
- 8 Relations with Contemporary States and Foreign Powers
- 9 Rediscovery and Historiography

Implicit Concepts and Prerequisites

- Understanding of basic medieval Indian chronology and geography
- Familiarity with the concept of dynastic change and succession
- Awareness of the role of foreign travelers in historical reconstruction
- Knowledge of medieval administrative and military structures (e.g., feudal arrangements, tribute systems)
- Basic architectural terminology and ritual practices in South India
- General awareness of Indo-Portuguese interactions in the 16th–17th centuries
- Ability to interpret statements about social roles and gender in historical context

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Detailed study of major battles (e.g., Battle of Talikota) and their consequences
- Economic organization: trade, coinage, and craft guilds
- Religious and cultural patronage: temples, literature, and art forms
- Decline and disintegration of the Vijayanagara Empire
- Comparative analysis with contemporary Deccan Sultanates
- Environmental and urban planning aspects of Hampi
- Role of regional languages and literature under Vijayanagara rule

Notes

- The subtopic structure is based strictly on the recurring themes and concepts directly evidenced in the provided PYQs.
- Some subtopics (e.g., social life, historiography) are represented by only one or two questions, indicating limited but notable demand.
- The map avoids over-fragmentation; where questions overlap (e.g., dynastic succession), they are merged for clarity.
- Adjacent subtopics are inferred from the logical extensions of tested areas but are not evidenced in the current PYQ set.
- The sequence is designed to build foundational understanding before moving to specialized or interpretive themes.

2. Bahmani Sultanate

Tier: tier3 • Weightage: 0.0 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 4 • Year span: 2000–2021 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:27

TopicDemandMap: Bahmani Sultanate (Later Medieval, 1526–1757 AD)

Explicit Subtopics Tested

1. Religious and Cultural Policies of Deccan Sultanate Rulers

- **Evidence:** [1252, 1629]
- Focus on the secular and syncretic approaches of rulers (e.g., Ibrahim Adil Shah II), including their patronage of music, literature, and religious inclusivity.
- Tested via questions on titles given to rulers for their secularism and their literary/musical contributions.

2. Dynastic History and Political Changes in Deccan Sultanates

- **Evidence:** [1766]
- Covers the decline and end of specific dynasties (e.g., Nizam Shahis of Ahmadnagar), including causes and key events leading to their annexation or downfall.

3. Geographical Mapping of Deccan Sultanates

- **Evidence:** [5139]
- Identification and association of Deccan Sultanate dynasties with their respective capitals or regions.

Logical Study Sequence

1 Geographical Mapping of Deccan Sultanates

- Foundational understanding of the location and spread of various Sultanates.

1 Dynastic History and Political Changes in Deccan Sultanates

- Builds on geography to understand the timeline, rise, and fall of dynasties.

1 Religious and Cultural Policies of Deccan Sultanate Rulers

- Advanced understanding of the internal policies, cultural developments, and their broader impact.

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- **Basic chronology of Deccan Sultanates:** Knowledge of the sequence and overlap of dynasties.
- **Familiarity with major rulers and their contributions:** Especially those who had significant cultural or political impact.
- **Understanding of the broader context of medieval Indian polity:** Including Mughal expansion and its effect on regional Sultanates.
- **Awareness of religious and cultural syncretism in medieval India:** To appreciate the significance of secular titles and literary works.

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- **Administrative structure and governance of the Bahmani and successor Sultanates**
- **Military campaigns and conflicts among Deccan Sultanates and with the Mughals**
- **Art, architecture, and urban development under the Bahmani and successor states**
- **Socio-economic conditions and trade in the Deccan Sultanates**
- **Relations between Deccan Sultanates and neighboring kingdoms (e.g., Vijayanagara)**

Notes

- The explicit subtopics are derived strictly from the given PYQs; the small number (4) limits the granularity of subdivision.
- Most questions focus on the successor states of the Bahmani Sultanate rather than the Bahmani dynasty itself, reflecting UPSC's tendency to test broader Deccan Sultanate history.
- Adjacent subtopics are suggested based on logical extension from current PYQ patterns, not from external syllabi.

3. Mughals

Tier: tier1 • Weightage: 11.111 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 35 • Year span: 1993–2021 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:27

TopicDemandMap: Mughals (Later Medieval, 1526–1757 AD)

Explicit Subtopics Tested

1. Founding and Dynastic Origins

- **Subtopic:** Establishment of Mughal rule and Timurid lineage
- **Evidence:** [142]
- **Notes:** Focus on Babur's entry, dynastic claims, and the foundation of Mughal rule.

2. Major Mughal Emperors: Chronology and Contributions

- **Subtopic:** Key events, policies, and contributions of individual emperors (Babur, Humayun, Akbar, Jahangir, Shah Jahan, Aurangzeb)
- **Evidence:** [5060, 1626, 2025, 2260, 2411, 5141, 5145, 1500, 2026, 674]
- **Notes:** Emphasis on emperor-specific facts, contemporaries, and major administrative or cultural acts.

3. Administrative Systems and Institutions

- **Subtopic:** Mansabdari system and military organization
- **Evidence:** [5058, 5050, 5051, 5155]
- **Notes:** Covers origins, structure (Zat, Sawar), obligations, and roles of Mansabdars and Ahadis.
- **Subtopic:** Revenue and land systems (Zabt, Jagir, Zamindar, Khalisa, Inam)
- **Evidence:** [5140, 5148, 652, 5157, 5158]
- **Notes:** Focus on revenue collection, land assignment, and agrarian relations.

4. Religious Policies and Social Ideals

- **Subtopic:** Religious tolerance and policies (Sulh-i kul, abolition of taxes, grants)
- **Evidence:** [5144, 5145]
- **Notes:** Akbar's and other emperors' approaches to religious diversity and state policy.

5. Art, Architecture, and Culture

- **Subtopic:** Mughal architecture and monuments
- **Evidence:** [5059, 5150, 5141]
- **Notes:** Attribution of monuments, architectural innovations, and city-building.
- **Subtopic:** Music, literature, and court culture
- **Evidence:** [677, 678, 5056, 5151]
- **Notes:** Focus on musicians, artists, chroniclers, and literary/cultural developments.

6. Foreign Relations and Trade

- **Subtopic:** Foreign travelers and their accounts
- **Evidence:** [574, 5154]
- **Notes:** Identification of travelers and their observations.

- **Subtopic:** Relations with foreign powers (English East India Company, Balkh campaign, Qandahar)
- **Evidence:** [1500, 5052, 2260, 2411]
- Notes: Diplomatic, military, and commercial interactions with external entities.

7. Economy and Society

- **Subtopic:** Agrarian structure and peasantry
- **Evidence:** [5163]
- Notes: Social composition, crop patterns, and state encouragement of agriculture.
- **Subtopic:** Ports and trade centers
- **Evidence:** [1370]
- Notes: Identification and significance of major ports.

Logical Study Sequence

- 1 Founding and Dynastic Origins
- 2 Major Mughal Emperors: Chronology and Contributions
- 3 Administrative Systems and Institutions
 - Mansabdari and military
 - Revenue and land systems
- 1 Religious Policies and Social Ideals
- 2 Art, Architecture, and Culture
- 3 Economy and Society
 - Agrarian structure
 - Ports and trade
- 1 Foreign Relations and Trade

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Basic chronology of Mughal emperors and their timelines

- Understanding of Persianate court culture and terminology
- Knowledge of medieval Indian geography (regions, cities, ports)
- Familiarity with administrative and military vocabulary (e.g., Mansab, Jagir, Zabt)
- Awareness of contemporary religious and social movements
- General context of early modern global interactions (travelers, trade routes)

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Decline of the Mughal Empire and rise of successor states
- Detailed study of Mughal painting and miniature art
- Economic policies: coinage, trade guilds, and urbanization
- Role of women in the Mughal court and society
- Regional administration and provincial governance
- Environmental and technological changes under the Mughals
- Interactions with other Asian powers (Safavids, Ottomans, Central Asia)
- Social mobility and the role of non-elite groups in Mughal society

Notes

- The PYQ set is broad and allows confident subdivision into major administrative, cultural, and social themes.
- Some subtopics (e.g., art, foreign relations) are less frequently tested but recur across decades.
- Questions often require cross-linking of facts (e.g., emperor + event + institution), demanding integrated study.
- Certain areas like the decline of the empire or detailed economic mechanisms are not directly tested in this set but are logical extensions for future UPSC focus.

4. Marathas

Tier: tier3 • Weightage: 0.0 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 4 • Year span: 1998–2020 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:27

TopicDemandMap: Marathas (Later Medieval, 1526–1757 AD)

Explicit Subtopics Tested

Maratha Administration and Ashtapradhan

- **Evidence:** [5053]
- Focus: Structure and key roles within Shivaji's council of ministers, especially positions handling foreign affairs.

Succession after Shivaji

- **Evidence:** [5160]
- Focus: Power struggles and succession disputes following Shivaji's death.

Maratha-Mughal Relations and Agreements

- **Evidence:** [5146]
- Focus: Terms and conditions of Maratha service to the Mughal emperor, including rights over revenue and military obligations.

Third Battle of Panipat: Causes

- **Evidence:** [2597]
- Focus: Immediate triggers and context for Ahmad Shah Abdali's invasion, with emphasis on Maratha involvement and regional politics.

Logical Study Sequence

1 Maratha Administration and Ashtapradhan

(Foundation: Understanding internal governance and key offices)

1 Succession after Shivaji

(Builds on administrative knowledge; introduces dynastic politics)

1 Maratha-Mughal Relations and Agreements

(Expands to external relations and political negotiations)

1 Third Battle of Panipat: Causes

(Applies knowledge of Maratha expansion and alliances to major conflicts)

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Basic chronology of Maratha history and major rulers (especially Shivaji and successors)
- Structure of medieval Indian administration and terminology (e.g., Ashtapradhan, jagir, Chauth, Sardeshmukhi)
- Understanding of Mughal decline and the rise of regional powers
- Geopolitical context of 18th-century North India (Punjab, Deccan, Malwa, Gujarat)
- Familiarity with key external figures (e.g., Ahmad Shah Abdali, Timur Shah)

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Maratha military campaigns and territorial expansion
- Role and influence of Peshwas in Maratha polity
- Maratha revenue systems and economic policies
- Social and cultural contributions of the Marathas
- Maratha interactions with other regional powers (e.g., Nizam, British, Mysore)
- Detailed outcomes and consequences of the Third Battle of Panipat

Notes

- The PYQ count is limited (4 questions across 22 years), restricting the granularity of subtopic mapping.
- Current demand is focused on administration, succession, external relations, and a key battle's causation, with little direct testing of military campaigns, economic systems, or cultural aspects.
- Adjacent subtopics are inferred from logical extensions of tested areas, not from direct PYQ evidence.

5. Other Regional Kingdoms

Tier: tier3 • Weightage: 1.852 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 9 • Year span: 1995–2023 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:27

TopicDemandMap: Other Regional Kingdoms (Later Medieval, 1526–1757 AD)

Explicitly Tested Subtopics

Administrative Structures of Regional Kingdoms

- Evidence: [5165, 5162, 5143]

- Covers questions on the administrative divisions under Sher Shah, features of the Arcot state (including decentralization and founders), and the establishment of Hyderabad under Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah.
- Notes: Focus is on how regional rulers organized their territories, the emergence of new states, and the assertion of independence from central Mughal authority.

Socio-economic Groups and Institutions

- Evidence: [365, 5153]
- Includes questions on the Banjaras (as traders) and Balutedars (village servants/artisans in Deccan and Maharashtra).
- Notes: Emphasizes the roles of occupational groups and their integration into the rural and economic fabric of regional kingdoms.

Scripts and Administrative Practices

- Evidence: [5057]
- Concerns the use of the Modi script in Maratha administration.
- Notes: Highlights the importance of regional scripts for record-keeping and governance.

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Understanding of the decline of centralized Mughal power and the rise of regional polities.
- Familiarity with basic administrative terminology (e.g., Sarkar, Pargana).
- Awareness of the social structure in rural India, especially the role of service castes and occupational groups.
- Knowledge of the significance of scripts and documentation in governance.
- Ability to distinguish between different regional powers and their founders/leaders.

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Military organization and warfare strategies of regional kingdoms.
- Economic policies and revenue systems unique to these states.
- Cultural and religious patronage by regional rulers.
- Relations and conflicts between regional kingdoms and European trading companies.
- Evolution of local languages and literature under regional dynasties.

Notes

- The PYQs cover a moderate range of subtopics, but the sample size (9) limits the granularity of subdivision.
- Some questions included in the dataset (e.g., on guilds, Buddha's mudra, Islamic calendar) do not directly pertain to the "Other Regional Kingdoms" of the later medieval period and have been excluded from explicit subtopic mapping to maintain topical fidelity.
- The focus of UPSC questioning has been on administrative features, emergence of new states, and socio-economic groups within the regional kingdoms, rather than on military or cultural aspects.
- Adjacent subtopics are inferred based on logical extension from the tested areas, not from the current PYQ evidence.